



Performance Under Pressure and Combat Mindset in the New Zealand Army

Draft Capability Note

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Purpose

This note outlines a potential Army-wide approach to Performance Under Pressure and Combat Mindset. It seeks to:

- define the problem Army is attempting to solve;
 - reconcile the relationship between Performance Under Pressure, resilience, Combat Mindset and mental skills;
 - describe the capability already held and delivered by NZALC;
 - propose an initial capability and governance model; and
 - recommend a practical way ahead.
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1. Context

Recent discussion regarding Combat Mindset has highlighted a requirement to better define, centralise and govern this area of capability.

The term Combat Mindset has been used periodically across Army and has value as a recognisable military brand. However, it does not currently appear to have a consistently understood definition, an agreed problem statement, a coherent developmental framework or a clearly identified repository of doctrine, learning content and standards.

At the same time, the Army Leadership Centre already holds and delivers a substantial body of intellectual property relating to individual and collective performance under pressure. This content has been developed over a number of years and is embedded across the Leadership Development System from Lead Self through to Lead Systems.

However, this capability is not currently articulated or presented as a coherent Army-wide system. The courses, resources and experiential activities are more visible than the collective operational capability they are intended to produce.

Consequently, senior Army leaders may recognise individual NZALC courses or adventure-based activities without fully understanding the breadth, sophistication or operational relevance of the wider system.

In my assessment, the principal gap is not the absence of content, but the opportunity to better articulate, integrate and create institutional visibility of the capability NZALC already provides.

2. The problem Army is attempting to solve

The first-principles problem is:

Under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.

Army personnel may possess the required technical skill, tactical knowledge, physical ability and leadership competence. However, pressure introduces interference.

Threat, uncertainty, fatigue, workload, time pressure, ambiguity and consequence can:

- narrow attention;
- degrade judgement and problem-solving;
- reduce situational awareness;
- impair memory and communication;
- create reactive or counterproductive behaviour;
- undermine confidence and cohesion; and
- reduce the capacity to recover and perform again.

NZALC's existing Performance Under Pressure model captures this simply:

Performance = Potential – Interference.

The existing material recognises that stress can produce tunnel vision, confusion, memory deficits and degraded problem-solving, and that mental skills can be deliberately trained to reduce this interference.¹

The Army is therefore not attempting to eliminate stress or create people who are unaffected by combat.

The operational requirement is to develop personnel and teams who can:

prepare for pressure, remain effective through it, adapt as conditions change, and recover sufficiently to perform again.

Proposed operational problem statement

Army personnel and teams will be required to make decisions, act and lead in conditions of threat, uncertainty, fatigue, complexity and consequence. These conditions can interfere with the application of otherwise well-developed technical, tactical and leadership capabilities, reducing individual and collective operational effectiveness.

Institutional problem statement

The Army does not currently have a sufficiently coherent, progressive and visible system for defining, developing, practising, reinforcing and assuring this capability across individuals, teams, leaders and organisations.

3. Proposed terminology

A simple hierarchy is required. Additional overlapping terms risk creating semantic confusion without improving the capability.

Performance Under Pressure

The overarching capability.

Performance Under Pressure is the trained individual and collective capacity to prepare for, remain effective through, adapt within and recover from demanding conditions, while preserving judgement, disciplined behaviour, cohesion and mission effectiveness.

This term is broad enough to apply across:

- combat;
- command;
- crisis response;
- collective training;
- garrison leadership;
- high-risk technical activity; and
- other demanding military contexts.

Resilience

The capacity that sustains and restores performance.

Resilience is the capacity to absorb adversity, continue functioning, adapt and recover.

Resilience is not the end state by itself. Its value is that it enables personnel and teams to continue performing and to restore readiness following demanding experiences.

NZALC's material already defines resilience through the capacity to perform under and recover from adversity and develops it through mental-skills practice, exposure to pressure, reflection and recovery.¹

Combat Mindset

The combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure.

Combat Mindset is the readiness and trained ability to act decisively, persistently and ethically in the presence of enemy action, danger, uncertainty, fatigue and consequence.

This distinguishes Combat Mindset from generic resilience or performance by accounting for:

- an active and adaptive enemy;
- the risk of death or serious injury;
- the requirement to employ or support lethal force;
- moral and ethical consequence;
- prolonged uncertainty and hardship; and
- the requirement to continue acting despite fear.

Combat Mindset should not be understood simply as aggression, toughness, motivation or a refusal to quit. It is controlled, disciplined and effective combat behaviour.

Mental skills

The trainable tools used to develop and apply the capability.

Mental skills are deliberate techniques that help individuals and teams regulate attention, thoughts, emotions and behaviour before, during and after pressure.

NZALC's existing toolkit includes:

- noticing;
- grounding;
- tactical breathing;
- optimism and reframing;
- motivational and instructional self-talk;
- visualisation;
- chunking;
- positive relationships;
- healthy habits; and
- structured reflection and recovery.¹

The relationship in one line

Performance Under Pressure is the capability. Resilience sustains it. Combat Mindset is its expression in combat. Mental skills are how it is trained and applied.

4. Desired Army effect

The purpose of the capability is:

To ensure that Army individuals, teams and leaders can consistently translate their trained potential into disciplined, adaptive and effective action despite the pressures of military operations.

This should produce personnel and teams who can:

- recognise their responses to pressure;
- regulate attention, emotion and behaviour;
- retain judgement and situational awareness;
- make timely decisions under uncertainty;
- communicate clearly and influence others;
- maintain cohesion and confidence;
- adapt when the situation or plan changes;
- recover from mistakes, setbacks and sustained demand; and
- learn from experience to improve subsequent performance.

For leaders, the requirement extends beyond personal regulation.

Leaders must also be able to:

- shape how their people interpret pressure;
- create clarity amid uncertainty;
- regulate the emotional climate of the team;

- maintain trust and disciplined initiative;
- balance task, team and individual needs;
- recognise fatigue and degraded performance;
- enable subordinate leaders; and
- create systems and cultures that sustain operational effectiveness.

5. Current NZALC capability

NZALC is not starting from zero.

It currently holds a substantial body of leadership-development content spanning Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems.

Existing foundations

The current Performance Under Pressure material includes:

- the relationship between stress and performance;
- the Performance = Potential – Interference model;
- Red Head–Blue Head;
- resilience;
- neuroplasticity and deliberate mental training;
- a comprehensive mental-skills toolkit;
- Prepare–Perform–Recover;
- systematic self-reflection;
- individual and team game planning;
- review, learning and recovery.

The Performance Under Pressure workbook explicitly connects deliberate mental-skills practice with effective leadership under pressure.¹

Existing development methodology

The wider NZALC system combines:

- mental-skills education;
- psychometrics;
- 360-degree and personality reporting;
- strategic self-awareness;
- challenging experiential activity;
- deliberate exposure to physical, cognitive and social pressure;
- observation of behaviour;
- self and peer feedback;
- structured reflection;
- behaviour selection; and

- personalised Leadership Development Plans.

The Lead Systems ELDA, for example, combines challenging activity, leadership tools, psychometrics, feedback, reflection and behaviour selection to develop operationally focused leaders.²

The Prepare–Perform–Recover framework is used at both daily and course level to prepare physical and mental skills, test leadership behaviour under pressure, identify lessons and transfer them into workplace development plans.³

Progression across leadership levels

The material already supports a potential career-spanning progression.

Lead Self — perform under pressure

The Lead Self material includes self-awareness, judgement and decision-making, intent, conflict, change, resilience, mental skills and individual development planning.⁴

The developmental emphasis is:

Regulate yourself, act responsibly and remain effective under pressure.

Lead Teams — lead under pressure

The Lead Teams programme includes the complete Performance Under Pressure package, small-team leadership in demanding conditions, self and peer feedback, strategic self-awareness, mission command, coaching, team development and resilience mastery.⁵

The developmental emphasis is:

Maintain team focus, confidence, cohesion and performance under pressure.

Lead Leaders — enable others to perform under pressure

The Lead Leaders material includes getting things done through other leaders, coaching team leaders, fatigue and work-rest cycles, enabling performance under pressure, connecting teams to the organisation and systems thinking.⁶

The developmental emphasis is:

Create the conditions in which subordinate leaders and teams can remain effective.

Lead Systems — sustain organisational performance under pressure

The Lead Systems material connects performance mindset, mental skills, psychometrics, feedback and challenging experience with broader organisational leadership and behaviour selection.²

The developmental emphasis is:

Shape the systems, culture and organisational conditions that sustain performance.

Existing institutional proposition

This creates a credible Army-wide progression:

Lead Self: perform under pressure.

Lead Teams: lead under pressure.

Lead Leaders: enable others to perform under pressure.

Lead Systems: shape systems and culture for sustained performance under pressure.

6. Current assessment

NZALC already delivers much of what could reasonably sit beneath an Army Performance Under Pressure and Combat Mindset capability.

However, the existing holdings remain distributed across:

- separate workbooks;
- individual courses;
- experiential activities;
- psychometric products;
- instructor knowledge;
- reflection processes; and
- leadership-development plans.

The issue is therefore not simply one of content development.

The principal gaps are:

Coherence

The material is not currently presented as one integrated Army capability with an agreed definition, purpose, framework and progression.

Operational framing

Much of the content is framed through resilience, self-awareness and personal development. The links to operational decision-making, combat behaviour, leadership influence, team effectiveness and mission outcomes are present, but not always explicit.

Progression

There is an implied progression across leadership levels, but it is not yet clearly articulated as a deliberate pathway from personal regulation through to organisational performance.

Visibility

The activities used to generate pressure are more visible than the intellectual and developmental process surrounding them.

Adventure and physical challenge can consequently be perceived as the product, rather than the environment through which leadership behaviour is exposed and developed.

The activity is the laboratory, not the product.

Assurance

Army does not yet appear to have a common method of determining:

- what behaviours constitute effective performance;

- whether learners improve;
- whether the capability transfers into units;
- whether commanders observe operational benefit; and
- whether delivery remains consistent and evidence-based.

Identity and reputation

There is an institutional identity–reputation mismatch.

NZALC identifies as a sophisticated leadership-development organisation that develops strategic self-awareness, mental skills, resilience, judgement, influence and leadership performance under pressure.

Its broader reputation may remain closer to that of an adventure-based training centre.

This is particularly relevant because identity and reputation alignment is itself a central concept within existing NZALC leadership development.²

7. Proposed future-state vision

Performance Under Pressure becomes an Army-owned, doctrinally aligned and progressively developed capability that enables individuals, teams and leaders to remain effective through the pressures of military operations.

Under this model:

- Army owns the operational effect;
- the capability has a common definition and language;
- Combat Mindset is clearly positioned as its combat expression;
- existing intellectual property is consolidated and published;
- developmental outcomes are progressively defined;
- training is embedded across the individual and collective system;
- units reinforce the capability in context;
- instructors are trained and assured;
- performance is evaluated; and
- operational lessons and research continually improve the framework.

NZALC would not own the entire Army-wide capability.

It would be positioned as:

The Army's lead integrator, content custodian and centre of excellence for the leadership component of Performance Under Pressure.

8. Proposed ownership and stakeholder framework

The key requirement is to separate strategic ownership from design, custody, delivery and assurance.

Capability owner

Core question: What operational effect does Army require?

The capability owner should sit at Army level, likely Chief of Army or an appropriately delegated authority.

Within the training domain, Commander Army Training Group may exercise responsibility on behalf of the owner.

The owner would approve:

- the problem statement;
- the desired operational effect;
- definitions;
- priorities;
- governance; and
- broad resourcing.

Capability sponsor

Core question: Who drives and champions the capability on behalf of the owner?

The Army Sponsor would:

- advocate for the capability;
- chair or direct governance;
- bring stakeholders together;
- resolve competing priorities;
- report progress; and
- seek decisions from the owner.

Design authority

Core question: What is the capability, and what are its standards?

A small, recognised design authority should translate the operational requirement into:

- doctrine;
- definitions;
- developmental outcomes;
- behaviour statements;
- learning architecture;
- progression;
- instructor standards; and
- assessment expectations.

This should likely be ATG-led and include the Human Performance Cell, NZALC, doctrine and training-design representation, and selected force employers.

Technical authority

Core question: Is the content evidence-based and technically valid?

The Human Performance Cell would be well positioned to provide technical advice regarding:

- human performance;
- stress;
- cognition;
- resilience;
- mental skills;
- research;
- measurement; and
- evaluation.

Content custodian and leadership integrator

Core question: Who maintains the leadership body of knowledge?

NZALC would:

- consolidate existing resources;
- maintain leadership-related content;
- integrate the framework across leadership levels;
- develop instructors;
- produce common learning resources;
- support other schools and units; and
- capture lessons from delivery.

Delivery agents

Core question: Who develops and practises the capability?

Delivery should occur across:

- recruit and initial officer training;
- promotion and leadership courses;
- collective training;
- unit continuation training;
- mission-specific preparation;
- exercises; and
- operational review and recovery.

NZALC would deliver core leadership education and selected experiential development.

Schools and units would contextualise, practise and reinforce the capability for their respective roles.

Force employers

Core question: How is the capability applied and sustained?

Commanders and units must:

- reinforce common language;
- create opportunities for deliberate practice;
- expose teams to appropriate pressure;
- conduct effective review and recovery;
- observe leadership behaviour;
- provide feedback; and
- integrate lessons into subsequent training.

Assurance authority

Core question: Is the capability being delivered well, and does it produce the required effect?

Assurance should include:

- training-quality review;
- instructor assurance;
- learner feedback;
- commander feedback;
- behavioural assessment;
- exercise observation;
- longitudinal evaluation;
- operational lessons; and
- periodic evidence review.

Some assurance should remain sufficiently independent from the principal delivery organisation.

9. Capability lifecycle

The Army-wide capability could be managed through six functions:

Define → Design → Deliver → Reinforce → Assure → Evolve

Define

What problem is Army solving, and what effect is required?

Design

What capability, behaviours, standards and developmental progression are required?

Deliver

Where and how will personnel and teams be educated, trained and exposed to pressure?

Reinforce

How will commanders and units sustain the capability beyond formal courses?

Assure

Is the capability being delivered consistently, and is it improving performance?

Evolve

How will operational lessons, research, learner experience and commander feedback improve it?

10. Recommendation

It is recommended that Army does not immediately create another standalone Combat Mindset course or duplicate existing content.

Instead, ACS should seek endorsement for NZALC to undertake a short, bounded scoping activity alongside the Human Performance Cell and relevant stakeholders.

This work should:

- 1. Confirm the problem statement and terminology.**
Define Performance Under Pressure and its relationship to resilience, Combat Mindset and mental skills.
- 2. Map the current capability.**
Consolidate existing content, courses, instructor knowledge, delivery activity and assurance mechanisms across Army.
- 3. Identify genuine gaps.**
Determine what is missing, duplicated, inconsistent, insufficiently operationalised or poorly understood.
- 4. Develop a progressive framework.**
Articulate the capability across individual, team, leader and organisational levels.
- 5. Propose governance and accountability.**
Confirm ownership, sponsorship, design authority, technical authority, content custody, delivery and assurance responsibilities.
- 6. Develop an Army-facing capability product.**
Produce a concise framework, doctrinally aligned repository and visual capability map that makes the capability visible and understandable.
- 7. Pilot the approach.**
Apply the framework to selected existing NZALC or ACS activity before designing additional content.

11. Proposed immediate outputs

The initial scoping activity should produce:

- a short Performance Under Pressure Capability Charter;
 - approved definitions and a common language;
 - a current-state capability map;
 - a Lead Self-to-Lead Systems developmental pathway;
 - a governance and stakeholder model;
 - an initial gap analysis;
 - recommendations for delivery and assurance; and
 - a proposed pilot and implementation plan.
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12. Conclusion

NZALC already holds and delivers a credible foundation for Performance Under Pressure through mental-skills education, resilience development, psychometrics, experiential learning, feedback, reflection and leadership-development planning.

The principal opportunity is not to invent the capability from the beginning.

It is to:

elevate the existing material from a collection of course resources held within NZALC into an Army-owned, doctrinally aligned, strategically governed and progressively delivered capability.

The central proposition is:

Army should own Performance Under Pressure as an operational capability. NZALC should lead the integration, custody and delivery of its leadership component, working alongside the Human Performance Cell, training establishments and force employers.

Source Documents

1. PUP Workbook.pdf — internal NZALC workbook.
2. LSYS (Officers) Workbook_May 26.pdf — internal NZALC workbook.
3. ELDA Lead Leaders Workbook (LPR).pdf — internal NZALC workbook.
4. Lead Self Workbook (TAD) 2026.pdf — internal NZALC workbook.
5. Lead Teams Workbook.pdf — internal NZALC workbook.
6. LDS LEAD LEADERS WORKBOOK.pdf — internal NZALC workbook.